

Select the Right Model

Monday Moments · AI Fluency · Week 5

What does this task require, and which model or tool fits those constraints?

Choose a model for the task and constraints, not for a universal “best” label.

Today's finish line

DO THIS See the core move.

WHAT THIS MEANS

Compare capability, context, cost, latency, privacy, and verification needs.

DO THIS Try it on a bounded example.

WHAT THIS MEANS

Choose a local model for a short private classification task versus a long-context synthesis task.

DO THIS State evidence and limits.

WHAT THIS MEANS

A comparison table, explicit criteria weights, observed test, and a bounded choice.

What does this prove, and what does it not prove?

DO THIS → WHAT THIS MEANS → FIND THIS YOURSELF → DEMAND DOCUMENTATION
VERIFY ON YOUR MACHINE → KEEP THE RECEIPT

The mental model

The idea

Model selection is a fit decision: task demands meet tool capabilities and operational constraints.

The boundary

A benchmark, model label, or one successful response cannot prove fitness for every task, input, or risk profile.

FIND THIS YOURSELF Before accepting a conclusion, name the observation that would support it.

A worked computing example

DO THIS Apply the idea to this bounded case: Choose a local model for a short private classification task versus a long-context synthesis task.

First pass

- ▶ What is known now?
- ▶ Which step or assumption is visible?
- ▶ Where is the checkpoint?

Professional move

Define the task and failure cost first; test two plausible options on a safe representative case and preserve the result.

Label the application: This is an instructor/computing translation, not a claim about the primary source.

What does this task require, and which model or tool fits those constraints?

Predict

What would you expect if the first story were incomplete?

Compare

What alternative explanation deserves a fair test?

PAIR TALK: Make one claim, one reason, and one uncertainty visible.

Do this: make the move visible

DO THIS Write task, constraints, criteria, candidates, test case, and decision rule before asking which model is “best.”

1. Write the task, decision, or claim in one sentence.
2. Mark the relevant stages, evidence, comparison, or criteria.
3. Choose one checkpoint before you act or explain.
4. Say what would make you revise, stop, or continue.

VERIFY ON YOUR MACHINE A good first attempt leaves a receipt another person can inspect.

What the source supports — and its limits

Supports

- ▶ The canonical move is to select against the actual task and criteria, then verify the chosen route.
- ▶ A clearer question and a more bounded next move.

Does not prove

Selection does not guarantee correctness, security, fairness, or future performance; conditions can change.

Is this safe? Is this secure?

How do I know? Where can I verify that?

Recovery: when the first story fails

PAUSE

A failed check is information about the route.

Use one bounded recovery

1. Preserve the observation and context.
2. Name the assumption or step to inspect.
3. Make one smaller retry or ask for help.
4. Do not turn uncertainty into a confident story.

Watch for: Choosing by popularity, one benchmark, or a confident answer without checking the task context.

Keep the receipt

DO THIS Record the smallest useful evidence.

- ▶ Claim or decision
- ▶ Observation and context
- ▶ Reasoning / comparison / checkpoint
- ▶ Result, limit, and next action

Exit move

Build a mini model-comparison table for one task: criteria, evidence, choice, and what would trigger reevaluation.

KEEP THE RECEIPT A concise receipt beats a confident story.

Your next move

Build a mini model-comparison table for one task: criteria, evidence, choice, and what would trigger reevaluation.

How will you know?